

Featured here is a 33.6 Kbps fax with up to 250 pages of fax memory. The broadcasting and delayed fax features are standard, and you can broadcast to up to 119 locations. In addition to the RJ-11, there is an Ethernet port as well as USB connectivity, but there's no parallel port. Take note of this if you have an older system.

HP bundles along the HP ToolBox FX, using which you can monitor device status and also manage fax tasks and set up e-mail alerts—this means you'll receive an e-mail when an event, such as a fax reception, occurs. HP provides Readiris Pro 11 for Windows, a premium OCR software, and also Readiris Pro 11.5 for Mac.

The monthly duty cycle of these MFDs is 10,000 prints. We did expect a higher duty cycle, though, because these two MFDs are in the high-end category and also expensive. The cartridge has a duty cycle of 3,000 prints and costs Rs 3,025; cost per page works out to just over a rupee. While we'll admit that the print quality is in a class of its own, the running cost is on the higher side.

The HP LaserJet 3390 and 3392 are priced at Rs 36,999 and Rs 46,999 respectively. Get one of these only if print quality and speed is of prime importance and if running costs don't matter much.

Brother MFC-8460N and MFC-8860DN In the heavy-duty league

Meant to handle the most rigorous of office tasks, these two models from Brother are very similar on all fronts. They have the same footprint of 53.1 x 45 cm, meaning they're a bit too large for most desktops. They even have very similar dashboards; the MFC-8860DN just has one additional button for Duplex (this is signified by the D in the model name): the MFC-8860DN has an inbuilt duplexer that lets you print on both sides of a page. The 50-page ADF also duplexes, allowing you to scan and fax both sides of a page. You can opt to copy both single- and double-sided originals to your choice of single- or double-sided copies using the front panel menu and button. These feature a five-line backlit LCD that provides a lot of information.

Built very ruggedly, these weigh a little over 16.5 kg, making them the heaviest in this test. The input tray holds 250 sheets, while the output tray supports 150 sheets—more than adequate, we'd say. They also have a multipurpose paper tray with a capacity of 50 sheets.

The printer, fax, and scanner specifications are exactly the same for the two. The printer supports a high hardware resolution of 1200 x 1200, and comes with 32 MB of buffer memory, expandable to 544 MB. Printing is very fast with text documents, and even with our combi-document, the first page takes 12 seconds instead of under 10 seconds for the text document—hardly a difference. Text is not sharp at Draft quality, but it is flawless at best quality. We saw fine text repro-

duced with good detailing in high quality mode.

Both these MFDs have large Legal-size flatbed scanners in addition to the sheet-fed scanner option. The scanner resolution is 600 x 2400 dpi (optical) at 24-bit colour depth. The scanner is fast, taking under 9 seconds to scan a monochrome document, and 100 seconds for a colour document. We saw colours and fine details captured beautifully. Both units performed very well indeed in our OCR test.

The dashboard sports the one-touch dialling option for up to 40 fax numbers. These MFDs have plenty of fax memory, 600 pages. A handset would have been a welcome addition, but neither of these two models even have the option to add one.

The first document copy took us 12 seconds, and it reached a speed of 30 ppm thereafter. The copies we saw were good, but shades of grey—and also some finer details—weren't perfect.

In addition to the USB and parallel port interfaces, these two also feature the fast 10/100 Ethernet interface. Bundled is the MFL-Pro Suite, which allows you to send faxes using your PC if you do not want to use the standalone fax exclusively. PaperPort 9.0SE adequately takes care of your OCR needs.

A bundled Driver Deployment Wizard helps you set up these as network MFDs. Like the other Brother MFDs, these ship with drivers for Mac in addition to those for Windows.

The MFC-8460N and MFC-8860DN have a toner duty cycle of 3,500; the toner cartridge costs just Rs 2,150, meaning an economical 61 paise per page. With a printer duty cycle of 20,000 pages per month, the MFC-8460N and the MFC-8860DN—which cost Rs 33,750 and 41,650 respectively—are more suited for larger businesses, of the order of an enterprise.



Brother MFC-8860DN



Brother MFC-8460N

Contact Sheet—Laser MFDs

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